Rules of 9-Ball Billiards

9-Ball is a fast-paced and popular rotation pool game. The core principle is simple: you must always strike the lowest numbered ball on the table first, but you win by pocketing the 9-ball.



The Objective

To win the game, a player must legally pocket the 9-ball. This can happen at any time during the game, including on the break, provided the lowest-numbered ball is struck first.

The Rack

- **Balls used:** Balls numbered 1 through 9, plus the cue ball.
- **Shape:** The balls are racked in a diamond shape.
- **Placement:** The 1-ball is placed at the apex (front) on the foot spot. The 9-ball is placed in the center of the diamond. The remaining balls are placed randomly around them.
- **Tightness:** All balls must touch each other tightly.

The Break

- The cue ball is placed anywhere behind the head string.
- The breaking player must strike the 1-ball first.
- To be a legal break, either a ball must be pocketed, or at least four object balls must be driven to one or more rails.
- If the breaker pockets a ball and commits no foul, they continue shooting.

- If the breaker commits a foul on the break, the incoming player gets ball-in-hand anywhere on the table.

The Push Out

- This rule only applies to the very first shot immediately following a legal break.
- The player whose turn it is may announce a "push out" to move the cue ball to a better position.
- During a push out, the cue ball does not have to contact any ball or any rail.
- After the push out, the incoming player has the choice to either shoot from the new position or pass the shot back to the player who pushed out.

Basic Gameplay

- **Lowest ball first:** The cue ball must *always* strike the lowest-numbered ball on the table first.
- **Continuing play:** If a player legally pockets any ball on a shot, their inning continues.
- **Combination shots:** You can pocket a higher-numbered ball (including the 9-ball) to win or continue your turn, as long as the cue ball strikes the lowest-numbered ball first.

Fouls

If a player commits a foul, their turn ends, and the opponent is awarded a cue ball-in-hand anywhere on the table. Common fouls include:

- Failing to strike the lowest-numbered ball first.
- Scratching (pocketing the cue ball or driving it off the table).
- Failing to drive any ball to a rail after the cue ball makes contact with the object ball (if no ball is pocketed).
- Driving an object ball off the table (the ball is not spotted, except for the 9-ball).
- Touching or moving any ball with a hand, clothing, or the cue stick (other than the tip during a legal stroke).

Winning the game

You win the game immediately if you legally pocket the 9-ball. Because 9-ball is a rotation game, you don't have to wait until it's the only ball left. You can win in three different ways:

- **On the break:** If the 9-ball goes into any pocket on a legal break shot, the game is over instantly and you win.
- **On a combination shot:** If you strike the lowest-numbered ball on the table first, and that ball (or another ball in a chain reaction) knocks the 9-ball into a pocket, you win.
- **At the end of a run:** If you clear the table in numerical order and legally pocket the 9-ball as the final shot.
- **Three foul rule:** If a player commits three consecutive fouls on three successive turns without making a legal shot in between, the opposite player wins the game.

8-Ball Pool — Game Rules

1. Objective

The objective is to pocket all **7 balls in your assigned group (Solids or Stripes)**, then legally pocket the **8-ball** to win the game.

2. Players

- 2 players
- Each player is assigned either **Solids (1–7)** or **Stripes (9–15)**.
- The **8-ball** is the final ball.

3. Rack

- 15 object balls are arranged in a triangular rack.
- The **8-ball is placed in the center** of the rack.
- The remaining balls are placed randomly.

4. Break

- The system determines who breaks first.
- The breaker strikes the cue ball from behind the head string.
- A legal break requires the cue ball to contact the racked balls.
- If a ball is pocketed on the break, the breaker continues shooting.
- The table remains **open** until a player legally pockets a called solid or stripe after the break.

5. Open Table

After the break, the table is considered **open**.

The player may attempt to pocket either a solid or stripe. Once a player legally pockets a ball, that group becomes theirs and the opponent receives the other group.

6. Legal Shot

On every shot:

- The cue ball must first contact a ball from the player's assigned group.
- The player must legally pocket their intended ball.
- Combination and bank shots are allowed, unless otherwise restricted by the game rules.

7. Continuing Your Turn

A player continues shooting as long as they legally pocket one of their assigned balls.

If they fail to pocket a ball, their turn ends and the opponent shoots.

8. Fouls

A foul occurs when, for example:

- The cue ball is pocketed.
- The cue ball first contacts an opponent's ball.
- The cue ball fails to contact any object ball.
- A ball is illegally knocked off the table.

After a foul, the opponent receives the ball-in-hand and may place the cue ball anywhere on the table.

9. Pocketing the Opponent's Ball

If a player legally contacts their own ball first but accidentally pockets an opponent's ball:

- The shot is considered legal.
- The opponent's ball remains pocketed.
- The player's turn continues if their own ball was also legally pocketed.

10. The 8-Ball

After pocketing all 7 balls in their assigned group, the player may attempt the 8-ball.

The player must:

- Call the pocket for the 8-ball.
- Make legal contact with the 8-ball.
- Pocket the 8-ball in the called pocket.

11. Losing the Game

A player loses if they:

- Pocket the 8-ball before clearing their assigned group.
- Pocket the 8-ball in the wrong pocket.
- Scratch or commit a foul while pocketing the 8-ball.

12. Winning

A player wins immediately when they legally pocket the **8-ball in the called pocket after clearing their assigned group**.

Game Format: 1v1 — First player to legally clear their group and pocket the 8-ball wins.

10-Ball Pool — Game Rules

1. Objective

The objective is to legally pocket balls **1 through 9 in numerical order**, then legally pocket the **10-ball** to win the game.

2. Players

- 2 players
- The game uses **10 object balls**, numbered 1–10.
- The **10-ball is the money ball** and must be legally pocketed to win.

3. Rack

- Balls **1–10** are arranged in a triangular rack.
- The **1-ball is placed at the front** of the rack.
- The **10-ball is placed in the center** of the rack.
- The remaining balls are placed randomly.

4. Break

- Players determine who breaks first.
- The breaker places the cue ball behind the head string.
- The cue ball must first contact the **1-ball**.
- If the breaker legally pockets a ball, they continue shooting.
- The breaker must still follow the **lowest-numbered-ball-first rule** after the break.

5. Lowest Ball First

On every shot, the cue ball must first contact the **lowest-numbered ball remaining on the table**.

For example:

- If balls 1, 3, 5 and 10 remain, the cue ball must first hit the **1-ball**.
- Once the 1-ball is pocketed, the next lowest ball is the **3-ball**.

6. Legal Shot

A legal shot requires:

- The cue ball to first contact the lowest-numbered ball.
- After contact, either a ball must be pocketed or at least one ball must contact a rail.

Combination shots are allowed, provided the cue ball first contacts the lowest-numbered ball.

Example:
If the 3-ball is the lowest ball remaining, the player may hit the 3-ball first and use it to legally pocket the 10-ball.

7. Continuing Your Turn

A player continues shooting when they legally pocket a ball.

If they fail to pocket a ball, their turn ends.

8. Fouls

A foul occurs when, for example:

- The cue ball is pocketed (scratch).
- The cue ball first contacts the wrong ball.
- No object ball is contacted.
- No ball is pocketed and no ball contacts a rail after the cue-ball/object-ball contact.
- An object ball is knocked off the table.

After a foul, the opponent receives the ball-in-hand and may place the cue ball anywhere on the table.

9. Pocketing the 10-Ball Early

If the 10-ball is legally pocketed through a combination shot **after the cue ball first contacts the lowest-numbered ball**, the player wins.

However, if the 10-ball is pocketed illegally or the player commits a foul on the shot, the 10-ball is **spotted back on the table** and the opponent receives the ball-in-hand.

10. Winning the Game

A player wins when they legally pocket the **10-ball**.

The 10-ball does **not necessarily need to be the last ball pocketed**. It may be legally pocketed through a combination or carom shot, as long as the lowest-numbered ball is contacted first.

Game Format: 1v1 — First player to legally pocket the 10-ball wins.